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Frank Tate

Frank Tate was born in Washington, D.C. on July 18, 1943. He started on trumpet but found his niche in the jazz world as a bassist. Frank played regularly with Marian McPartland and Dave McKenna in the '70s and toured with Pearl Bailey and the Louis Bellson Orchestra. He performs constantly at festivals here and abroad and can be heard on recordings with Warren Vache, Bobby Short and Butch Miles.

Frank was interviewed in Clearwater Beach, Florida on March 18, 2001, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in Clearwater Beach. I'm really pleased to have bassist Frank Tate with me here today. And I just heard a fantastic set of music with some of your cohorts, Dan Barrett and Howard Alden.

FT: I'd have to share your enthusiasm for it. We haven't worked together in a long time.

MR: It didn't sound like it.

FT: Well we rehearsed this afternoon so we get a little rust off, you know, scratching barnacles.

MR: But those are some kind of complex arrangements but you pull them off pretty easily. Do you play differently with that group?

FT: I don't know, I try never to play differently. I just try to play. And it either works or it doesn't. I can temper my style to a certain degree. For example last night, I don't know if you heard the Dick Hyman set, Dick said, "Look," he came to us before we played, he said, "let's take a different approach to this, just play this very loosely and let it go where it goes." And there's certainly the structure, you know, we're playing within the tune. So we'll go to a certain length but I don't try and do things that I can't do. So I'm usually called because of the way I play. I play a certain style and so I don't really have to think about it they already know what they're getting.

MR: I mean there's a fairly ambiguous direction anyway, let's play this fairly loose?

FT: Well yeah, but I was thinking the other day, it just amazes me, with really good players, how much really works. Monk made a record with Pee Wee Russell and Bernard Purdie is on a Louis Armstrong record. And I don't see people trying to change their style, they just go do what they do and when I think about it it really is pretty amazing how much does work if they're really fine players.

MR: Yeah. I guess you just have to listen.

FT: And if not nothing works.

FT: Yeah I grew up in Arlington. I was born in Washington and I grew up across the river in Arlington, Virginia, and I went off to Greensboro College and was a business major. And when I was 19 I started sitting in on trumpet, which was my first instrument. And I sat in and there were some clubs. And this was a time when you could go around to little joints here and there and sit in and play, and I got some experience that way. And then after I'd finished college, I had graduated, I was 23 years old. The guy that started me in the business on trumpet, a man named Burt Massengill who just had his 90th birthday, switched me to bass when I was 23. I hung around down there and I started playing bass and I moved back to Washington and was working days selling stereos and color TVs. And when I was 27, on April 1st—

MR: You remember that.

FT: Yeah, that was a date that will live in infamy, I left the day world for the last time and started playing full time.

MR: Left the day world.

FT: Yeah. In a huff. Stormed out on them.

MR: Let's work on your night club tan now.

FT: Yeah, right.

MR: So you came to the instrument at least kind of late in comparison to some people. Did you come to the music late though or was that always—

FT: Well no. I had Art Hodes' records when I was five years old. My older brother and Bob Hodes, Art's son, were in first grade together in West Hempstead Long Island. We lived there for a very brief period of time when I was like three, four and five. So my father and Art Hodes, and my mother and Art and Thelma Hodes they all became friends. And so I had these 78s. I have a few of them left. "Way Down Yonder in New Orleans" is on one side and a tune called "Save It Pretty Mama" is on the other side. I can't believe they got it printed back then you know. It's not a vocal. But I didn't pay much attention to it until, oh I had some Hackett records believe it or not. And I had an Art Tatum trio record which my mother bought for me to give to my step-grandfather for Christmas. And about two days later he gave it back to me.

MR: Is that right?

FT: Yeah. It was a record with Slam Stewart and Everett Barksdale. And it was a ten inch LP and I had it stolen in the 70s when I had a whole footlocker — my prize possessions gone.

MR: Oh dear.

FT: Yeah.

MR: Was Slam doing the thing?

FT: Oh yeah, yeah sure. And so but I don't know, when I was in high school, that's when I really got the bug. And a buddy of mine took me to hear Dizzy Gillespie one night, he was adjudicating a festival at Georgetown University. The second place band was a six piece bebop band led by Paul Winter.

MR: Whoa.

FT: Yeah. Like a Art Blakey style band. And they came in second. And then Dizzy played. And I'd never heard Dizzy on record, and being a trumpet player, I mean I am sure that my hair literally stood on end when he started playing for the first time. And I of course immediately raced out and bought everything. And then it was Miles and all the saxophone players and so the music I was listening to when I entered as a listener were the people that were hot at the time. Miles, Cannonball, Wes Montgomery, Wynton Kelly, Wayne Shorter, those kind of people. I had to go back and find out about Louis. To me Louis meant nothing to me at the time. It was just an old guy.

MR: Yeah. I guess that's usually the way it happens.

FT: Yeah. I'm sure it is. But once I got interested in the earlier music then I really went back and took a good long hard look at it and got emotionally involved in it, and then it became part of me just like the music of the 60s, you know, the Wes Montgomery things that I still get out and listen to all that stuff. I love that music period.

MR: Did the rock & roll of the time, the upcoming rock & roll people affect you at all?

FT: I never listened to them.

MR: Okay.

FT: I flunked a Beatles test one time. I couldn't name all four of them.

MR: Get out.

FT: I figured — yeah — I think I left out George Harrison of all people, the bass player.

MR: No McCartney is the bass player.

FT: Well see there you have it.

MR: You're still flunking it.

FT: Right, well I'm proud of that. That's a badge. I'll wear that proudly. After the Platters and the Clovers and the Drifters and Fats Domino and a few bands and Chuck Berry and bands like that, by the time I got to college, dance parties and stuff you know, but I was already nicknamed Thelonious Monk by then.

MR: Really.

FT: Well a friend of mine laid that on me when I was a sophomore in college.

MR: I'm sorry, that's my nickname. You can't—

FT: Well I guess it is at that. But I used to, when I was in high school, I was right outside Washington where the Howard Theatre is. And I used to tell my mother and father, "I'm

probably go to hear Shorty Rogers or somebody. I heard Nancy Wilson when she was maybe 21, right after she had done the two Capitol albums. And she was eight feet tall and weighed a hundred and fifteen pounds and pure dynamite in a floor length blue dress. And the curtain opened and the audience went [gasp], and she slayed them. And I heard Redd Foxx, I heard Moms Mabley, I heard Quincy Jones' big band, I heard Miles with, I think, Cannonball and Coltrane and I'm pretty sure Bill Evans but my memory of the sidemen back then — this was at a time when I was still trying to figure out where Trane stopped and Cannonball came in. I was still trying to sort out the difference between the sound of a tenor and an alto because I was just, you know. But I would show up two hours early to go hear — and even later on when I was legal to get into bars I'd go to hear Miles. I'd show up at eight o'clock. I'd be at the table at eight for a nine o'clock set. I was so infected by the whole thing.

[I'm sorry, we just lost your mic, Monk]

MR: The reason I lit up is because my favorite album in the whole world is Cannonball and Nancy Wilson, on Capitol.

FT: Oh sure, yeah. They do "Happy Talk" and —

MR: "Save Your Love for Me."

FT: Yeah. With the quintet, with Nat and Lou Hayes and

MR: Joe Zawinul.

FT: Zawinul, excuse me, Zawinul. I have a trio record of his called "To You With Love" that was purchased at the Tate Street Drug Store in 1963 for a dollar. It's on a label called Strand. And Louis Porter, who has everything ever — you know Louis?

MR: Um hum. I don't know him but I know who he is.

FT: He found the record, it's in a catalog that's Joe Zawinul playing straight ahead, no funk, no rock & roll, acoustic piano trio record. Are we up again?

[Monk, you talk]

MR: I'm talking. Yeah I'm a real Cannonball nut.

[okay]

MR: And just that record just is it for me, Perfect.

FT: Yeah I thought that was the best material she ever did. You know record companies they get into somebody.

MR: Yeah and she took heat for it too she told me.

FT: I'm sure she did. Cannonball must have taken heat for "Mercy, Mercy, Mercy" and all that stuff. I mean I don't know the record business you know. I don't know how these characters operate at the desk you know, but these guys they get an advance and then they've got to sell records. And Cannonball started doing all that pop music and Nancy

Wilson did a record where there was a tune on there called "It's All Over Mr. Walker I Don't Want the New York Secretary's Life." A country & western tune.

MR: Wow.

FT: So I mean I doubt that was a, you know, but I heard when you know.

MR: And you saw her when.

FT: I saw her, yeah, I sure did.

MR: Well let me just pick up here. So in the Washington club scene you were really getting exposed to a great variety of players. Is that a fair statement?

FT: Well there were several really fine clubs. First of all Bohemian Caverns, and the late, great Tony Taylor who owned this place, he used to let me in there when I was underage and you could start drinking in Washington when you were 18 and he'd make sure that I didn't get in too much trouble, you know. He kept me on a pretty short leash. He'd let me in because he knew I was just totally crazed about the music. And you know I was, many, many nights I was the only white kid, white person in the club maybe within five miles, the way the scene in Washington and Northern Virginia and all that was back in early 1960. You know those were the days with segregated high schools. And I was going, Tony would see that I didn't get out of line. But I saw a lot of people there: Roland Kirk, I saw Coltrane's quartet a little later on in '62 or 3 when I was in college at that point. And Blues Alley was there and I used to go over to Blues Alley after work every night. And I heard all kinds of people there. And I confronted the owner at that time, a man named Bill Cannon, Colonel Bill Cannon U.S. Army Retired, Colonel Cannon, okay, owned a jazz club. And he was a very decent guy. An ex-pilot, a second World War bomber pilot I think. And he hired me once and asked me to lead the house band. And I had had no name experience of any kind. And I had a drummer and a piano player, and a drummer. So a good friend of mine, Tom Bailey, lives up near me, and we didn't know anything. The first people we worked with was Wild Bill Davison came in and then Bobby Hackett, Urbie Green came in, Zoot came in, Al Cohn came in, Anita O'Day, that was fun. It was different.

MR: Yeah?

FT: Oh yeah, well, she's nothing if she's not interesting. And she had a good week though. She had some trouble there, she had a drummer once who quit on Tuesday night, he said — I think his name is John Poole. And he said, "I just can't stand any more of these two day weeks." She'd go in and get fired by Tuesday. But she had settled down.

MR: She was a little strung out sometimes, wasn't she?

FT: Yeah. She was. A great singer, oh please. And Teddy King sang there, Maxine Sullivan, and I worked with all these people. And I was like a sponge at this point. I mean they

were bringing in music and at this point I was just barely learning how to read and I was trying to figure out what a C seventh was and—

MR: Is that right and you're playing behind these people?

FT: I had a good ear. I mean I knew whether a chord was a minor chord or a major chord without having to be told but it was at this point that I started getting into the text and was learning to read and figuring out changes, learning what chord symbols, what they really meant and what all that fruit salad, you know the plus eleven and all that stuff hanging off, dangling off the end of a chord meant and what to do with it. And I stayed there about a year and a half and Bobby Hackett asked me to come on the road with him to a place named Dunfy's. Dunfy's Hyannis Resort which we immediately named Dummy's High Handed Resort. It was run by a bunch of gangsters at the time.

MR: Really.

FT: Well not gangsters but we were going to be there about five years and we lasted about five minutes. We all got fired. And the night we got fired, within a couple of months maybe, and Bobby had had his first major diabetic attack and it really set him back and he never really got well from it. This was in '74 and he died in '76 so he never really got over his first diabetic attack and it finally took him away. But the night we got fired a man named Warren Mannows, who has left us, he owned a place down the road on the Cape, this was down in I guess West Dennis, in a place called The Columns. It was West Dennis. And Dave McKenna was working there. And he asked me, he said, you know my ship had sunk. We were fired, I had a girlfriend living with me at the time, I had no money, and I had committed to a summer rental and she had left her job for the summer and taken a leave of absence and here we were on the Cape and about a week after we got settled in we were all fired. And the same night this man Warren Mannows asked me how would I feel about spending the rest of the summer working with Dave McKenna. Well he pulled me down from the ceiling, my head was stuck in it, my ship rose to the surface and sailed off. And I spent the better part of four years working with Dave. Everybody else was down at Berklee, and I was a little old for that anyhow. They were down there playing modal and learning scales and stuff. I was learning tunes like "Ship Without a Sail" and all this stuff and Dave just — he never called a tune, he never gave a tempo, he didn't do anything, he just sat there and started playing. And you were either on board or you weren't. And it was just night after night after night for one year. We started in May and finished on New Year's Eve. That was the summer season. And one night we played duo — I can remember one night we played duo in the room on like a Wednesday night, a cold, rainy, late October night, for about thirteen people sat in the lounge. And they stayed from the first note to the last and you could hear the ice cubes

was a sponge at this point. I was really trying to soak up everything I could. And I was living in New York at the time. I had a $150 a month apartment and I'd just go in on June first and lock the door and turn off the electricity and come back in January or whatever. And I was also working with Marian McPartland at that time. So I was juggling a fairly serious calendar. And that was a wonderful gig for me. Because I had that gig when I moved to New York. So instead of coming to New York looking for a job I came to New York working with Marian with her trio.

MR: How did you get hooked up with her?

FT: Well I met her in Washington and she told me, she and I are still very close so I talk to her a good bit and I see her when I can, and we're fast friends. And she told me she said, "You basically need to get out of Washington" is what she said to me. She said, "If you come to New York I'll put you to work." And I did and she did. She was good to her word. And we went to work in Rochester at the Round Town Motor Inn on Route 252A, Henrietta Boulevard.

MR: I've been there.

FT: Why I can remember that I'll never know but I guess because the whole thing made such a profound impression upon me. Jules Moss was playing drums at the time and then later Ted Moore, who wound up playing marimba with a Brazilian symphony. A great musician. But we went to work, I went to work with Marian without a rehearsal. It was like McKenna. We didn't have a talk through. We went up there and hit. Started playing. And things would start to evolve arrangement wise. And of course she already had her arsenal of certain things, but beyond that, she was down for anything. If she didn't like it she'd shoot you a look, you know. But we were trying all kinds of stuff.

MR: Like you said, that was your Berklee.

FT: Yeah. That and the Dave McKenna gig, I mean really.

MR: You can't get any better.

FT: Marian's tunes, her choice of tunes, like Dave's was exquisite. I mean we were doing Strayhorn and she'd sketch a lot of stuff out for me later on. She had a real fast hand and she'd write out changes. And she was a very fine writer. She's written all kinds of great tunes, one of which I've recorded, "Twilight World." It was a title tune for a limited issue CD I did. Talk about a vanity project, every dime of it was mine. And I think I sold about five of them and I gave away about four hundred.

MR: I know how that works.

FT: Well I was just trying unabashed self-aggrandizement you know. But maybe that's not the word. But I was just trying to promote the trio and of course we never got a single gig. But I got the date out and then it got my name out and that was the point of it.

MR: Well when I look at the list of other people you've been with, unfortunately most of them are gone.

FT: My fault — I killed them all. It's really awful. It's kind of embarrassing. Well they were all going to live forever if it weren't for me, right. But what the truth of the matter is is I was lucky enough and I was very young and these were some very old people and I got in on the tail end of some really great careers. Venuti, Hackett, Zoot. I stayed around with Zoot for a while. I worked with Zoot in New York. I worked with Zoot up until right before he died and did a couple of recordings with him. Jimmy Rowles. I got to work with Teddy Wilson some. That was interesting.

MR: Tell me about Joe Venuti.

FT: Do I have to?

MR: Yeah.

FT: Well I found out something afterwards that really changed my opinion of him. When he came to The Columns and worked with Dave and Kenny Hawkins on drums and I was playing bass, he was very relaxed and very at ease and had a great time and swung like mad and was taking everybody to dinner, was the toast of the Cape and you know he was really having a ball. Because with Dave and the trio he didn't have to think about a thing. He'd call a tune and Dave was in there even if we weren't. And Dave was solid as the Rock of Gibraltar and Joe loved coming up there. And then when I worked with him with a different band he was kind of a load, he was kind of hard to handle. And it turned out he was very ill and I didn't know it. And only one or two people knew about it. He subsequently died and he was a difficult person. But he was always an unrefined load of gold or whatever, I don't know what I'm looking for here. He was basically I don't think he had much formal education. He had a lot of musical education. He was a very fine violinist and when he was very young was I think he considered a symphony career. But I was very fond of him despite it all. I was crazy about him. And he was quite ill and none of us knew it.

MR: Yeah. Quite a practical joker, wasn't he?

FT: Uh, I didn't see that. But I mean I heard all the stories. But you know that story about all the bass players on the corner? Well I heard him tell it to some New York people that it took place on Hollywood and Vine and I heard him tell it to some California people and it took place at 52nd and Broadway, and I've never met anybody who met anybody who knew anybody who knew anybody that was involved. I really question the whole thing. And then there's another story, we don't even have to go into that, you know the one I'm talking about, I'll pass on that. But I don't know it seems like I guess it's in the Sudhalter book on Bix, the story of Whiteman firing Venuti and Whiteman, it was somehow after a

follow him and he found a two by four and put some oily rags on it and lit him on fire and led the band. Again, I don't know anybody that ever saw any of this stuff happen.

MR: Right. What's myth and what's reality?

FT: Jazz lore you know.

MR: Right. How about Benny Goodman? What was it like to work with him?

FT: I worked with him once and he hated me. He walked into the rehearsal looking at me like I'm looking at you. Looking at the side of my face. I should have right then and there said Benny, thanks, another time. But he had three gigs for me. And I've got to preface this by saying that Benny was at times a very odd duck but I'm not calling him on his musicality, don't misunderstand me. I fully appreciate everything that he did and his worth as a player. And a lot of guys liked him. And they got along with him. They understood. Even some guys that had a lot of trouble with him and still liked him and that's understandable. But he had it in for me from when he walked in — we rehearsed at Mel Lewis' house and Benny came in glaring at me. So we were supposed to go to New Haven. And Benny was playing $200 in town and $300 out of town. And then when the gig was over, Loren Schoenberg was working for Benny and Loren called me up the next day and he says Frank I have bad news. And I said well I know I'm off the band. He say no, no, it gets worse. He had been like championing me. He's trying to get me on the band you know, and of course Benny despised me from I guess it was my East Falls Church, Virginia Protestant look or something. I don't know what it was. But we were oil and water. And Loren says, "It gets worse, I was writing you out a check for $300 because you were in New Haven last night, 75 miles out of New York. And Benny comes around and says, "Oh no, no, no, no," he says, "New Haven is in town." So Benny still owes me a hundred dollars. I guess I lose, right?

MR: Yeah I guess not.

FT: I'm not getting it. But I'm sorry it didn't work out because I felt like I would have been a good bass player for him. It would have been a good situation for me. I thought I could have done the job. I knew the music and I'm sure I would have learned a whole lot. I think Mel Lewis and Britt Woodman were on that band that night and I've forgotten, some other really fine people. And I would have loved to have stuck around for a while. First of all I could have made a lot of money, because he was still working pretty much. But it just wasn't meant to be and Benny's got my hundred dollars.

MR: I think he probably got a few other people's too.

FT: I don't know.

MR: Everybody seems to have a story.

FT: Benny was playing a concert one night with Zoot Sims and people threw some money up on the stage and Benny bent down and picked up a dollar bill and Zoot snatched it right out of his hands and said, "I need that more than you do."

MR: I see you've worked with some great singers too.

FT: Yeah.

MR: Bobby Short recently?

FT: Bobby, a singer to end all singers. Oh I've been with him full time for four and a half years. I replaced a guy named Beverly Peer, a man that had been with the Chick Webb band. He was 84 when he resigned, in the middle of a night. He couldn't get through the second set. He was very ill and Bobby called me up and Bobby said, "What are you doing?" I had rehearsed with him that day and the day before. Rehearsed the show. Because that Beverly was on the brink. And Bobby called me at nine o'clock and says, "What are you doing?" I said, "I'm in my pajamas watching T.V." And Bobby said, "Well you'd better get your ass into your tuxedo and get in here because it's starting, the second show, and it's going to be televised for Brazilian television." And I had music spread — Bobby didn't like music on the stand, and of course I memorized it all as quickly as I could and got rid of it. And these like Opus, these like medleys, and pages flopping around and everything. But I got through it and Beverly died within five or six weeks. He died mid-January, and I came in back around the fifth or sixth of December of '96. And Beverly didn't stay around very long. But he worked right up until the end. He was with Bobby for 38 years and I told Bobby, that night I came on I said, "Hey I want 38 years." And I did the math and realized it would make me 91. And he said, "Well what do you think that's going to make me?" So I said, "Okay well let's try for ten." And he said okay. So I'm not quite half way through the ten year plan and then I'm going to re-negotiate with him again. And he's doing fine.

MR: Does he go from coast — or from Europe?

FT: He lives in, he has a place in the South of France, I believe it's called Mouzon. My French is kind of not real strong, but he has, it's referred to as a villa. And I've seen pictures of it and it is, and he's got orchards, and he's got 3-1/2 acres and a pool and a nice apartment in New York. He's had a heck of a career. Started very early. He had some lean times but he went out to L.A. when he was eighteen and he just sort of went out there and placed himself on the A list where he's been ever since. He worked for the right people, played the right music, was very smart, spoke French when he was in high school. He went on the road when he was eleven with a tutor. He said, "I had to become a man when I was eleven and then when I was fourteen," he said. "I went back to Danville, Illinois I had to start being a boy again." Because somebody would say something about

shot." And then Bobby said I had to forget about all of that and go back to school and be a high school boy again. And then he went out to California and bought himself a big black Cadillac convertible, riding around Hollywood when he was eighteen or nineteen, maybe twenty, in a convertible. He's extremely interesting and talent like from day one. Tremendous ears. Hears everything. Totally self taught and he's a joy to work for.

MR: What's it like in this particular time period to make a living as a jazz musician?

FT: I have a wife with a real job so it's not too bad. My wife works for Doubleday Books, she's the — well her title I guess it's the Director of Promotional Art. But I mean she works and I stay busy. I've always worked. I knew going in that I wasn't going to make any money money. I make a living and I work. And it's two hours a day. I get my golf in by day and I'm not into 60 hour weeks. My father did that and lived to the ripe old age of 61. Forget it. I'm very happy and I'm very, very happy when I think about my circumstance. Because I came at it from a very funny angle. I had no education in music as a kid except trumpet lessons, and I didn't have any formal education on string bass. I watched bass players. I figured — I got a hold of the Simandl book, then I had a couple of teachers and got the bend out of my wrist and got my arm straightened out and my fingering. And I watched good bass players and watched how they played. And why they held their body a certain way and it started making sense. You know if your wrist is cocked it's like a support beam with a bend in it. This makes more sense than this, and things like that. And this makes more sense than this. This is stronger and I started figuring it out. And I mostly relied on my ear. And so the point was, and I was 27 before I started playing full time. And had a serious battle with alcohol that lasted from the time I was 16 until I was 30. And it wasn't really until, when I went on the wagon in 1973, within six months I was out of Washington and off working with Hackett and then McKenna and Marian McPartland, so when I dried out everything good started happening to me at once. And so coming at it from the angle that I came at I sort of crashed the party, and sort of late in life too, I mean, to have made it in this business. It still surprises me when I think about it that I'm doing what I want to do in New York, and it's what I've been doing for 30 years, the same thing. I don't teach, I don't write, I didn't ever want to do any of that, all I ever wanted to do was be a bass player and a performer, and that's exactly what has happened. So I caught a big break.

MR: Knock wood, right?

FT: Yeah, exactly.

MR: What do you think of some of the young players coming up on the instrument?

FT: Oh I hate 'em. The bass players? Yeah. Well I hated the way Milt Hinton played but if you were a bass player trying to make a living in this business you'd hate him too. Oh I

than ever, but with the exception of some of these jazz parties and stuff it's kind of like sports. It's almost like it's a kid's game. I see myself looking at I don't know what down the road. I don't see — and these jazz parties, how long are they going to go on?

MR: Right. When you look at the audience.

FT: Yeah well it's the audience. And my late brother died a couple of years ago would be at 60 or 61 now, and he died a couple of years ago. He rode around in his car listening to 50s R&B. People 55 years old now talk about Grand Funk Railroad or whoever. They don't know. People crowding 60 have had no exposure to this music. They don't know beans about it. And that really doesn't bode very well for us, but now modern music with this post-Wynton Marsalis invasion — it's not an invasion it's just people have gotten away from other kinds of music and are going back. There's a lot of great jazz being played and all over the world at concerts. And a lot of these guys are doing very well in the business too. And all the more power to them. It seems like there's a whole bunch of young people out here now with a lot of business savvy. They're taking care of the business end of the music as well. And some of them have learned in school. They've taken courses in how to manage a career. I missed that one. But no I think what's happening is great. I'm not really crazy about a lot of what I hear. I think a lot of what I'm hearing is extremely derivative and it's from everybody. I don't hear a lot of new, I mean we're fresh out of Charlie Parkers and Coltranes. And sometimes I think about music and I think it's been covered. And then I hear about things like ska bands and world music and I don't want to know from any of that. I only want to know about jazz music. I'm not interested in the confluence of any other — that's just me personally. Keep your music out of jazz. I'm sorry. That's an old person's point of view but—

MR: You don't want to hear jazz and Irish reels together.

FT: No. I don't. I really don't. And if I did I'd probably like it. I'd rather not hear it and not like it.

MR: What's going to be on your calendar for the upcoming — the same?

FT: Bobby Short starts, we are in mid-March now as we speak and Bobby starts, well I'm going this coming Tuesday, today being Saturday, I'm going down to Vero Beach with Ruby Braff and Bill Charlap and a couple of other fellas, I don't even who the con— we're going to go down there and do a concert. And then we come back here and record Thursday and Friday with Jerry Jerome who is 89. Dick Hyman is writing the music for it. Tommy Newsom is on it and some of the folks in this festival here. And then next month I'm going to Atlanta. I actually, we were supposed to start the Carlyle in early May and I booked a big jazz party in Atlanta with a record date in front, a record date on the back end of it, and a Sunday night concert with Ed Polcer in addition to it. So there

told him, I've got this booked, I can't get out of it. And so I'm actually sending a sub into the Carlyle for three nights. I'm going to hear about that.

MR: I hope he doesn't do too well.

FT: Well I do too. I'm going to get somebody who can't make it at all. I was always told send in somebody better. Cover your gig. I don't buy that at all. I just send in some bum.

MR: He'll be so glad to see you.

FT: Yeah right. No I've got somebody, the truth is someone good is going in. But I'm doing that and then back to the Carlyle until the end of June. And then Bobby goes to France and I freelance. I just start working the phones. The phone doesn't ring as much now. First of all the business is a little odd these days, but everybody assumes I'm busy with Bobby so it's kind of my fault. I don't call enough people so I've got to get my network re-opened.

MR: Right. I've heard people talk about that, that people think that you're always working with somebody and they don't bother to give you a ring.

FT: Right. Or they think well let's call somebody who isn't working so much that needs the gig. I need the gig. Are you watching? Anybody that's out there, help me.

MR: Okay, here's a hard question to answer for some people. But when something, even like at these parties when you're thrown together with all these different people, sometimes it might really swing and sometimes it might not.

FT: It might not.

MR: Is it possible to put into words why things do and don't?

FT: Well not really being a student of the history you know, I don't know why. And I don't know why bands will work one night and not another, I'm talking about the same band. Some things are so much better. Somebody said to Miles Davis one night, said, "Man, you sound beautiful tonight." And Miles said, "Well maybe you're just listening good tonight. Maybe you're having a good night." And I mean so his point was maybe it sounds good to you because you're in a good place. And when an audience, when you get enough people in an audience that are really in a good place, they'll send something across, the vibe to you, and you start sharing it back and forth and they start to pick up a little enthusiasm and you realize hey they actually are hearing this, and maybe we better play a little better, and it's interesting how it happens. But again, most things at these jazz parties, these people that work these jazz parties make these things work. If they couldn't or didn't or wouldn't, they wouldn't be asked back. So we have to get up there and look like we're having the time of our lives. And if you appear to be enjoying yourself, lo and behold sometimes you actually will, and you will start spreading the joy and the enthusiasm, and it will make the band work better. But some things are just really hard.

really goes wrong. Did you ever put a record, a needle down in the middle of a record, or flip on the radio in the middle of a jazz chorus and you don't know what planet these people are on. A lot of times non-players — I'd love to know what they hear. So the funny thing is when something is really, really good they know it. If it's bad — something wasn't quite right. Yeah the drummer was in five-four all night. They don't know that. But they're not sure why it isn't working real well. But when something, like the Alden-Barrett quintet, that set we just did a few minutes ago. Everybody in the room knew that was spot-on and there was no question about it. And you know it's funny. It's not hard to figure when something is really good but when it isn't — and the answer to your question is yes, some things just don't work too well. You put on your game face and you get out there and appear to be having the time of your life and sell it any way you can. Because attitude shows from a mile away. And if you're up there, oh man I'm so bugged with this, and have that kind of a like bebop mentality, with apologies to all my dear friends who play bebop including me who I do as well, but you know of what I speak. You have to know, and this I learned from Bobby Short, how to sell it. He went out one night, a blustery Tuesday in May, in a rainstorm. The second show there was four people in the room. And he went out there and launched a full frontal assault on these four people. The whole nine yards. The dialogue. The patter. Every tune. I mean and I just sat back and I said Frank Tate, man I says, you ought to take a lesson from this, and don't ever forget what happened up here tonight. Because this is why he is where he is and maybe that's why I'm a sideman. But well there aren't too many slots for Bobby Shorts in this world, but he's in his slot for a lot of reasons, not the least of which, well there's his talent of course, but making things work when he doesn't feel well. Like when he had this other bass player who was so sick on the stand. And you just have to get like really focused and go for it.

MR: Well that's a great statement about his entertainment value as well as his talent. But when you said bebop mentality—

FT: Oh that's just a— no I retract that.

MR: Yeah but okay, the idea that the music itself was enough. Like I don't need to try to entertain you.

FT: Yeah. Yeah, yeah yeah. Dizzy knew better. Dizzy always knew better. He knew where the money was and that was in sending people home happy. If they go home happy they'll come back. Al Haig never — I worked with him for a couple of weeks. He'd finish a tune by like [mumbles] almost an effort to keep people from applauding. It's like there was a wall up between, well he was an unusual guy. Brilliant talent. But didn't know the first thing about entertaining. And Zoot, who [mumbles] good night, thank you.

him, he'd say "he's so much fun to watch." He was also one of the funniest people on the planet without ever trying. Nothing was ever strained with him he was genuinely interesting, and boy did he have a hard — he had people that would lie down in front of a truck for him. His fans. Oh yeah. And people still talk more about Zoot than anybody, and people miss him. I miss Zoot Sims more than anybody than I can think of. I think about him all the time because of his personality. And he was loaded a lot of the time. And sometimes he was real mean and hard to get along with. And other times a strange, delightful guy. The best saxophone player you could ever dream of.

MR: Pretty much an intuitive musician?

FT: I think so, yeah. He at one point was a very good reader. I mean he was working in Woody's band. And like all good readers, I mean there were some people and always have been people in bands that couldn't read very well but could hear it and see it, and that would be enough. You'd put it up there to remind you what to play and their musicianship would rule the day and they could keep the gig because — Stan used to read something once and never look at it again, Stan Getz. They used to say that he had a mind like a steel trap about music. They said you could give him a complicated part and he'd play it once and put it away, when he was with Woody's band he never had the book out. Now I wasn't there, I didn't see any of that so I don't know and I only worked with him once.

MR: Can you recall one of your worst dates ever?

FT: How much time you got? I've had some embarrassing moments. The first night that the Alden-Barrett quintet worked, Chuck Wilson had to send in a sub. He had something he couldn't get out of. And Jerry Dodgion came in and Jerry made the rehearsal, and Jerry had written a tune called "Butter" dedicated to Quentin Jackson. And I had a bunch of parts of it around, and I had like two pages of a two part, I had two copies of page one and two copies of page two and I put one and one together and taped them together and put them up on the bandstand. And it was the first night of the existence of the band. And I got to the bottom and I went back up to letter A, and the tune blew up in mid air. It felt like a house of cards and we stumbled like a two-legged racehorse to the finish line and crawled across on our face and finished. And Jerry Dodgion turned around and looked at us and looked mostly at me and said, "Thanks guys, that was beautiful, just perfect." Big smile on his face. And we were all laughing. That was pretty horrible. And there have been things like that. But I haven't had — I've had precious few gigs that I really despised. There've been a few. I mean circumstances will — somebody in the audience, especially if you're doing a party for somebody and it's a private party. And fortunately for me, all those now, I'm hired and I go out and I work private parties with Howard

this band. And so we're known going in so there's none of this hey you guys go through the kitchen. Most of the gigs I play I'm part of the party, if I want to be, and so I don't have that problem much anymore. And there were some gigs that I've been on that were misery but it's only four hours a night max and it's over. How bad can it be? And all gigs end. I mean it's two weeks, three weeks somewhere and it's over. I've had some problems with some temperamental people and things, and they can really get underneath your skin. And it's too bad because I've seen really, really fine musicians wreck gigs. Guys that ought to known better. I say guys, people. Singers, men, women that ought to know better and ought to understand the psychology of what makes a band work well. You don't start a fight with somebody in your band. Buddy Rich used to, like there's a tape floating around of him railing on the band. These are a bunch of 20 year olds that he robbed out of Berklee, and they're great players all, and he just attacked them on the bus one night. And I had been hearing about this tape and I was all excited, I wanted to hear it, and I listened to like three seconds of it and I said I don't know what this is but it's not fun. It can't be fun for these guys, and it was really embarrassing. And all he had to do, because they all revered him, he was like such a superior player, all he had to do was say, "Yeah guys, that was just fantastic tonight" and they would have been even better the next night. They were all like 20 and 21, very impressionable, and that's not even an age thing. I mean compliments to a guy that's playing can really change the whole — I worked with, one night when I was working with Zoot we had been to Belfast and I had played on a strange bass. It's now a bass that I own, I bought it from the guy. But it was really big and difficult for me to play at the time. It had a big string length and it was very wide. And Zoot commented at the time, he says, "You've got some intonation troubles there." And I said, "Well Zoot, I'm using a borrowed bass." He says, "Yeah I guess you are." And then a couple of weeks later, in Chicago, I was back on my own instrument at the time and we had been playing steadily. And he laid a compliment on me that stuck with me to this day, and I mean I walked down, got off the elevator and walked down to my room three feet off the floor. And I was in my mid-30s then. You know, it wasn't child psychology he was using on me. So I just, why wreck a gig. You know his comment about the intonation was well taken, he wasn't trying to start a fight with me, but he had some tapes of it and he said, "Hey you know, this is something you need to look into." And I did. It made me think about it more. But he never went on a rant. Bobby never does either. Bobby can get angry, everybody can. He gets angry and then he gets over it and gets on with the next piece of business. If something bothers him he'll let you know, that's the end of it. He's very fair like that and he makes it clear that he's forgotten about it after it's over and it doesn't happen but once in a blue moon anyhow.

FT: The best. Yeah. I miss him. Because I was in his trio for three, a couple, two, three years. We rehearsed the first time up at my house in Croton-on-Hudson. And Howard brought Ruby up. And Ruby and I had never played together. And we were in my old study. And Howard's [scats] swinging like mad. Ruby's playing and Ruby's making, he's going [scats] and I knew immediately that he was digging it. And that trio was so good. We were so together there for a while. We made some nice records and did some good gigs and concerts. It was really, really sensational. And Ruby's at his best on the bandstand. That's the time that he enjoys the most. Everything else is marking time with him, waiting to get on the bandstand, as best I can figure him out. I mean I think it's what he really lives for. And he's passionately involved with it while it's happening. And he has a knack of leading — he led a group with seven or eight musicians last night and made it sound like they'd been on the road. He's directing traffic, pointing to this guy and that guy and working out things while it's — and a really devil may care attitude about — he'll go for anything. And when he goes for it he gets it, and he goes way down on the bottom of the horn like nobody can. His lower register is — and that's tough sledding down there. The fingerings are all awkward, those are the hardest fingerings, the bottom part of the horn are the ones where you've got to use two and three, one two and three, one and three, and it's very heavy and cumbersome, the fingering. And he's just down there wailing in the lower register. He's fearless.

MR: Great to hear that about him.

FT: He's 74 and I shouldn't comment about his health except to say I don't think he's doing so well. And everybody says, "Well if he's got a breathing problem, how can he play the trumpet?" Well if you look at the trumpet, the bell is this big around but there's not a column of air coming out. The column of air is this big around going into the mouthpiece. So that isn't the problem. It's just feeling well enough to go out there and put joy into it. And how he does it I don't know, he just gets up there, like last night it was earth shatteringly good music last night. And it was all because of him at the helm. I miss not working with him. Well I'm looking forward to this gig coming up this coming Tuesday because he'll have had a couple of days down here playing and we're traveling the day before so we'll be well rested, and we got Bill Charlap. Yeah. Wow. Where did this guy come from? Well I know where he came from, his father was Ray Charlap the writer and his mother is Sandy Stewart. I was talking about her the other night and I said Sandy Dennis or Sandy Duncan or something. And Bobby was laughing and he said, "No, you moron." I know who she is she's a club singer. A good singer. Broadway and cabaret I think. So he's on it and that'll be fun, a nice gig.

MR: The future's in some good hands there.

FT: Oh boy. He's got a record out, he did "The Man that Got Away." Ruby plays that too so I'm hoping we'll play it. It's [scats] it's as slow as you can get and swings so hard and he's just a real force to be reckoned with in this business. You know and I'm listening to him and he's in his I guess his early, mid-'30s, I don't know what his age is. But I was listening to a Jimmy Rowles record from the '50s the other day when Jimmy would have been about the age that Bill Charlap is now. And you listen to Bill Charlap and you think well there's no way he can improve on what he's doing. But he probably will. Listen to what Jimmy Rowles — listen to Clark Terry from the '50s and listen to the latter day Clark Terry and how his style and everything about him at some point in the '60s or whenever it was took a quantum leap forward in all respects. He was always a great player but he got considerably greater. And Jimmy Rowles did the same thing. And so I listen to guys like Harry Allen and Bill Charlap and I say there's no way they can improve on what they're doing right now but who knows. I hope I stick around long enough to see what they both do. Harry is another one. He's just a phenom. So.

MR: I really do like listening to him.

FT: Yeah, yeah. I have a CD coming out. We recorded it in Belfast in 1996 with Dave McKenna, Butch Miles, Harry Allen and Howard Alden and it's coming out in May. After four years the record label gets in touch with me, they've got to have the liner notes in three minutes. So I'm scrambling to write this stuff and it's for Nagel Heyer. Sabina and Hans Nagel Heyer, who are good friends. But once they decided they wanted to move on this thing, they wanted to move on it. So all right, write the liner notes, send them to me, I'll type them up, send them back to you, you correct them and send back a final copy. And so this was like the airwaves were cluttered for a few days and so it's on the way out. Harry — well that was four years ago and Harry was just brilliant.

MR: Well listen, this has been a great conversation.

FT: I've enjoyed it immensely. Thank you.

MR: I've enjoyed it, and I wish you all the best with your upcoming recordings and so forth.

FT: Thanks.

MR: Maybe I'll see you at the Carlyle.

FT: You should.

MR: I come to New York on occasion.

FT: Well bring some money. Bring a lot of money.

MR: I see that.

FT: It's expensive. But you know I've never seen anybody go out of there saying I got cheated on this thing. I have people go out of there foot tapping. It's a great show and it's definitely worth seeing.

FT: Thank you.

MR: Thank you.

FT: Thanks very much, it's a pleasure.